DECODING RIVAL STRATEGIES

CEC Gyanesh Kumar's decisions have become a rallying point for the Congress-led Opposition and the CJP. But this time around, the BJP and the Centre have a plan to counter it. Who will prevail?

By **Kaushik Deka, Anilesh S. Mahajan** and **Avishek G. Dastidar**

Earlier this month, a senior cabinet minister called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi on routine business and, as a courtesy, asked how he was doing. The PM, always ebullient and never short of ideas or opinions, had none to offer this time. "You know what's happening," he said. Indeed, the whole country knows. In the 12 years of its rule, the Modi government has weathered the anti-Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA) protests at Shaheen Bagh, the farmers' siege of the national capital and the wrestlers' sit-in at Jantar Mantar. Those battles were over laws, policies or individuals. This time, the referee is under scrutiny. On September 23, *The Indian Express* reported that election commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had raised 14 written objections to decisions issued in the name of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, mostly over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The revelations gave the Opposition forces validation for their allegations and became a rallying cry against the government. For Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, whose '*votechori*' campaign seemed short of evidence, dissent within the Election Commission of India (ECI) offered fresh ammunition. The challenge also came from the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), the student-led movement that had forced education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET paper leak controversy.

For the government, the stakes were existential. It could, grudgingly, repeal a law or sacrifice a minister, but acknowledging flaws in the electoral roll revisions risked undermining its own mandate. As the churn started in right earnest, three competing strategies emerged from the three sides.

THE FIRST MOVER

On September 23, Rahul Gandhi called *votechori* an "act of treason" by the BJP, RSS and ECI. On September 30, 19 Opposition parties resolved to fight the "theft of the people's franchise" with all its might. The agitation quickly gathered pace—an eight-hour sit-in at Akashvani Bhavan on October 6, a meeting with President Droupadi Murmu to petition for Kumar's removal and suspension of the SIR on October 9, an INDIA bloc march to the Supreme Court to file a joint petition under Article 32 on October 12.

The protest visuals have started taking effect, says Rajya Sabha MP Praveen Chakravarty, chairman of the AICC's data analytics department. He says an informal dipstick survey suggests even lay voters are now asking, "*Kuchh to ho raha hai aur sarkar chup hai. To kyun chup hai*? (Something is going on and the government is silent. Why?)" Chakravarty believes the Centre's silence has compounded its difficulties. "If there is nothing to hide, why is the ECI not holding a presser?" he asks.

Lok Sabha MP and Tamil Nadu Congress president Manickam Tagore claims the crisis has already cost the Modi regime its legislative calendar as it had planned a special session before the festive season. "Their plan was to have a session and pass the delimitation bill," he alleges. That never happened.

Meanwhile, the Congress is not boycotting the coming assembly polls despite the apprehensions





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